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Defining and Refining the Research Problem

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Books Reference:

1. Sekaran, Uma, and Roger Bougie. Research methods for business: A skill building approach. John Wiley & Sons, 2016.
2. C.R. Kothari - Research Methodology_ Methods and Techniques-New Age Publications (Academic) (1985)

What do you mean by problem?

Some difficulty which a researcher experiences in the context of either a theoretical or practical situation and wants to obtain a solution for the same

- Why there is so much economic inequality and poverty in the world?
- Why my friend is poor and I am rich?
- The introduction of flexible work hours has created more problems than it has solved.
- Young workers in the organization show low levels of commitment to the organization.
- Staff turnover is higher than anticipated.
- Minority group members in organizations are not advancing in their careers.

Problems Vs. Symptoms

“5 Whys by Japanese industrialist Sakichi Toyada”

“Minority group members in organizations are not advancing in their careers.”

Components of Research Problem

1. Individual or a group which has some difficulty or the problem.
2. Objective(s) to be attained at.
3. Alternative means (or the courses of action)
4. Some doubt in the mind of a researcher
5. Environment(s) to which the difficulty pertains.

What is Researchable?

- Interesting-sheds light to a unique phenomena/event
- Subject which is overdone should not be normally chosen
- Controversial subject should be carefully dealt.
- Too narrow or too vague problems should be avoided.
- Familiarity of researcher and Feasibility to conduct research:
 - Background knowledge
 - Affordability
 - Willingness of participants
- A brief preliminary (feasibility) study should be conducted to assess how researchable the problem is.

Process of Defining Research Problem

1. Stating the problem in general way

2. Understanding the nature of problem

3. Surveying the available literature

4. Developing the ideas through discussions

5. Rephrasing the research problem

1. Stating the problem in general way

- Problem should be defined in broad, general way
- Researcher should immerse himself in the subject matter
- Do some field observation
- Pilot study/survey can be conducted
- Seek the guidance of the guide or the subject expert
- Narrow down and phrase the problem in operational terms

2. Understanding the nature of problem

- Understand problem's origin and nature
- Discuss it with those who first raised it
- Enter into discussion with those who have a good knowledge of the problem concerned or similar other problems
- Study the environment within which the problem can be understood

3. Surveying the available literature

- Knowing what data are available often serves to narrow the problem
- The researcher must be well-conversant with relevant theories in the field, reports and records:
 - Gaps in the theories?
 - Whether the existing theories applicable to the problem under study are inconsistent with each other?
 - whether the findings of the different studies do not follow a pattern consistent with the theoretical expectations?
 - Type of difficulties that may be encountered?
 - New lines of approach to the present problem?

4. Developing the ideas through discussions

- Discuss the problem with colleagues and others who have enough experience in the same area.
- Experience survey.
- Understanding of the general approach to the given problem.
- Understanding of the techniques that might be used.
- Understanding the possible solutions.

5. Rephrasing the research problem

- The researcher must sit to rephrase the research problem into a working proposition
- Putting the research problem in as specific terms as possible so that it may become operationally viable and may help in the development of working hypotheses
- Research objectives and research questions should be defined

Other Considerations while Defining Research Problem

- Technical terms and words or phrases, with special meanings used in the statement of the problem, should be clearly defined.
- Basic assumptions or postulates (if any) relating to the research problem should be clearly stated.
- A straight forward statement of the value of the investigation (i.e., the criteria for the selection of the problem) should be provided.
- The suitability of the time period and the sources of data available must also be considered by the researcher in defining the problem.
- The scope of the investigation or the limits within which the problem is to be studied must be mentioned explicitly in defining a research problem.

Problem Statement

- **Research Objective:** The purpose or objective of the study thus explains why the study is being done.
- **Research Question:** specify what you want to learn about the topic.

Problem	Problem statement	
	Research objective	Research questions
Frequent and long delays may translate into much frustration among airline passengers, to switching behavior, and to negative word-of-mouth communication. These feelings and behaviors eventually have negative effects on the performance and the profitability of the firm.	The purpose of this study is twofold: (1) to identify the factors that influence the passengers' waiting experience and (2) to investigate the possible impact of waiting on customer satisfaction and service evaluations.	1. What are the factors that affect the perceived waiting experience of airline passengers and to what extent do these factors affect the perception of waiting times? 2. What are the affective consequences of waiting and how does affect mediate the relationship between waiting and service evaluations? 3. How do situational variables (such as filled time) influence customer reactions to the waiting experience?

Research Questions

- Example I:

The manager of a famous corporation is curious to know if the work ethic values of employees working in its subsidiary in Okara City are different from those of working in Karachi.

- Example II:

A bank manager wants to have a profile of the individuals who have loan payments outstanding for six months and more. The profile will include details of their average age, earnings, nature of occupation, full- time/part-time employment status, and the like.

- Example III:

- What factors were responsible for the higher labour productivity of Japan's manufacturing industries during the decade 1971 to 1980 relative to India's manufacturing industries?
- To what extent did labour productivity in 1971 to 1980 in Japan exceed that of India in respect of 15 selected manufacturing industries?

Define the problem statement (the why and the what) in the following situation?

In Pakistan, economic inequality remains a pressing issue, with substantial gap in income and opportunities between different segments of the population. One specific aspect that requires attention is the underrepresentation of women in the job market. Despite progress in women's rights of education and empowerment, many women still face significant barriers in accessing decent work and participating fully in economic activities. This unequal economic participation raises concerns about the broader economic implications and the need for targeted policies to promote gender equality and inclusive growth.

The logo of the Philippine University of Agriculture, Crop and Pest Management (PUACP) is positioned in the background. It features a shield with a green and yellow border. Inside the shield, there is a stylized green plant with a yellow sun-like shape above it. The acronym 'PUACP' is written in blue at the bottom of the shield.

CLASSROOM TASK

Define the research problem for the topic that you have chosen for your project.

Section of A Research Proposal

- The research proposal drawn up by the investigator is the result of a planned, organized, and careful effort, and basically contains the following:
 1. A working title.
 2. Background of the study.
 3. The problem statement:
 1. The purpose of the study
 2. Research questions.
 4. The scope of the study.
 5. The relevance of the study.
 6. The research design, offering details on:
 1. Type of study – exploratory and descriptive
 2. Data collection methods
 3. The sampling design
 4. Data analysis.
 7. Time frame of the study, including information on when the written report will be handed over to the sponsors.
 8. The budget, detailing the costs with reference to specific items of expenditure.
 9. Selected bibliography.